



ACME CORP

The Async Team Handbook

How we communicate without meeting

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2026-06-10 1.0



About this document

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Internal

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Why We Work Async

Asynchronous work means a clear message now and a thoughtful reply later. Nobody has to be online at the same moment for progress to happen. Done well, async gives every person long stretches of focus and a written trail anyone can follow.

This handbook is the shared contract for how our team writes, triages, and records the work that flows between us. It is deliberately short. Read it once, keep it nearby, and lean on it when a thread starts to drift.

Note

Async is the default, not a fallback. We reach for a live call only when a topic is genuinely ambiguous or emotionally charged — everything else is better in writing, where it can be searched, skimmed, and revisited.

1.1 The Three Promises

Every async culture rests on a few promises we make to each other. Ours are simple and we hold one another to them.

- **Write for the reader.** Assume the person catching up has zero context.
- **Reply within a day.** Even “I saw this, answering Thursday” counts.
- **Decide in the open.** Decisions live in the doc, not in a private DM.

Pro Tip

Front-load the *why* in the first two sentences of any message. A reader who understands the goal can often answer before they finish reading the details.

The goal of an async message is not to be read — it is to be understood without a single follow-up question.

1.2 A Quick Comparison

It helps to be explicit about what changes when a team commits to working async.

In Plain English

Sync is a phone call: fast, fragile, and gone the moment it ends. Async is a letter: slower to start, but it keeps working for everyone who reads it later.

Watch Out

Async is not an excuse to go silent. Slow is fine; invisible is not. If you need more time, say so in the thread before the day is out.

Writing a Good Message

A great async message does the reader's thinking for them. It states the goal, gives just enough context, and makes the next step obvious. The lifecycle below shows how one message travels from your keyboard to a recorded decision.

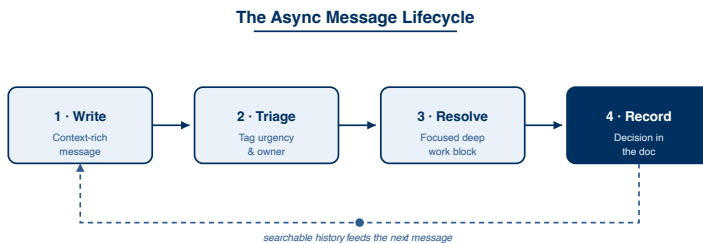


Figure 2.1: The async message lifecycle: write, triage, resolve, record, and feed the searchable history back into the next message.

Notice the dashed return path: every recorded decision becomes context that makes the *next* message shorter. That compounding is the whole point.

2.1 The Anatomy of a Request

When you need something from a teammate, give them everything required to act in a single pass. A complete request reads like a tiny brief.

Do

Lead with the ask, then the deadline, then the context. Link the relevant doc, state what “done” looks like, and name the one person who owns the reply.

Don't

Don't send “got a sec?” with no detail and wait. It forces a round-trip just to learn what you actually need, which defeats the purpose of writing at all.

For anything that touches other teams, write the bare URL of the source as a real link so readers can click straight through, for example the [team operating principles](#) or the [decision log template](#).

2.2 A Reusable Template

You should not invent the shape of a request from scratch every time. Copy the skeleton below into a new thread and fill in the four blanks — the structure does the remembering for you.

```
[ASK]      One sentence. What do you need, from whom?
[BY]       A real date/time, with a timezone. "EOD" is not a
↪ deadline.
[CONTEXT]  Two lines max, plus one link to the source of truth.
[DONE]     The observable outcome that lets us close the thread.
```

The tags are not decoration. A reader scanning ten threads can find the one that needs them by the [BY] line alone, and a future teammate can reconstruct the decision from the [DONE] line without asking a soul.

Pro Tip

Keep one thread per topic. When a side question appears, start a fresh thread and link back. A thread that tries to hold three decisions will lose all three.

2.3 Quick Reference

Pin this somewhere visible. It is the whole handbook compressed into a card.

CHEATSHEET

Write the goal first. **Tag** urgency and one owner. **Reply** within a day, even if only to acknowledge. **Decide** in the open. **Record** the outcome in the doc so the next message starts from a shorter runway.

Living the Practice

A handbook only matters if it survives contact with a busy week. These habits are what keep async healthy once the novelty wears off.

3.1 Protecting Focus

The reward for working async is uninterrupted time. Defend it on purpose.

- **Batch your replies** into two or three windows a day, not a constant trickle.
- **Mute by default** and opt into the few channels that truly need you.
- **Block deep-work hours** on the shared calendar so they are visible and real.

Note

A four-hour block of focus is worth more than a day of shallow availability. Treat your calendar as the place where async time is reserved and respected.

3.2 When Things Drift

Even a healthy thread occasionally stalls. Notice the signals early and act.

Watch Out

If a thread crosses three back-and-forths without converging, stop typing. That is the signal to switch to a fifteen-minute call, then write the outcome back into the thread for everyone who was not there.

In Plain English

A call inside an async culture is a tool, not a defeat. You use it to unblock, and then you return to writing — the call is the exception that proves the rule.

Some threads are not drifting — they are on fire. When something is genuinely blocking or time-critical, skip the etiquette and say so in one unmissable line.

CHEATSHEET

If a thread is blocking a release or a customer is affected, do not bury it in prose. Open with **BLOCKING** in the first line, name the one owner, and page them on the urgent channel. Async is the default; it is not a suicide pact.

That is the entire practice: write clearly, reply reliably, and leave a trail. Everything else is detail.

3.3 Glossary

Term	Meaning
Async	Communication that does not require both people to be present at once.
Thread	A single topic's conversation, kept separate from unrelated topics.
Triage	Tagging a message with its urgency and a single accountable owner.
Decision log	The durable doc where outcomes are recorded, not a private chat.

Term	Meaning
Deep-work block	A protected, calendar-visible window reserved for focused work.
Round-trip	One full exchange of question and answer; the cost async aims to cut.